Military Decision-Making Process (MDMP)

Quick briefing

Work through the seven steps of the Military Decision-Making Process using the 15-page SOAC 3.2 student handout. Explain what each step needs, what it produces, who leads it, and where the Signal officer adds C4S requirements while they can still shape the plan.

Know the facts

Seven steps · Receipt of mission, mission analysis, COA development, COA analysis (war game), COA comparison, COA approval, and orders production, dissemination and transition. The outputs of one step become the inputs of the next.

Warning orders · WARNORDs go out after Steps 1, 2 and 6 so subordinates can plan in parallel. Commanders allocate at least two-thirds of available time to subordinates and keep one-third.

Mission analysis · The most critical step. It produces the problem statement, mission statement, initial intent and planning guidance, initial CCIRs and EEFIs, updated IPB and running estimates, assumptions and COA evaluation criteria.

COA screening · Test each COA as feasible, acceptable, suitable, distinguishable and complete. War-game it without comparing COAs, then compare against criteria fixed beforehand.

Signal officer's role · Contribute through the C4S running estimate: assess supportability in the war game, put command posts and critical communications nodes on sketches, plan PACE means, recommend EEFIs and write Annex H (Signal).

Understand the reasoning

Time drives detail. The one-third / two-thirds rule and early warning orders protect subordinate planning time while the headquarters is still analyzing.

Criteria are set before COAs are compared, and war-gaming never compares COAs. This keeps the choice from being biased by the COA a planner developed or by what the commander is thought to want.

A decision matrix informs the commander's judgment. The lowest total is the most desirable COA, but the matrix rests on subjective ranks and criterion-by-criterion comparison is often more useful.

Philippine Army classroom exercise

A Philippine Army battalion staff in a classroom exercise has just received a brigade order with 48 hours before execution. The S3 has finished the first draft of the problem statement, and the S6 has found that the only route for a relay site is covered by a no-fire area set by the brigade.

Decision · How should the S6 and the staff handle the no-fire area, and how much of the 48 hours should subordinate units get?

Worked analysis · Record the no-fire area as a constraint, because it is a restriction placed by higher headquarters. The S6 should report the resulting C4S shortfall in the mission analysis briefing, add the relay site and critical communications nodes to each COA sketch, and recommend protecting relay locations as an EEFI. Under the one-third / two-thirds rule the battalion keeps about 16 hours and gives subordinates about 32 hours, supported by an early warning order.

How to practice

1 · Begin at receipt of mission: gather the order and products, update running estimates, assess time and issue the initial guidance and WARNORD 1.

2 · In mission analysis, analyze the higher order, perform initial IPB, sort tasks, constraints, facts and assumptions, and produce the mission statement, intent, planning guidance and evaluation criteria.

3 · Develop several COAs that pass the screening criteria and give each a statement and sketch showing the main effort and critical communications nodes.

4 · War-game each COA, record results on the synchronization matrix, and let each staff officer test the COA from his or her function without comparing COAs.

5 · Compare the COAs against the agreed criteria with a decision matrix, then brief the commander so he or she can approve, modify or reject.

6 · Turn the approved COA into the order, reconcile it with its annexes, crosswalk it with higher and adjacent orders, and hand it over to current operations.

Check yourself

Which steps are followed by a warning order? · Step 1 (receipt of mission), Step 2 (mission analysis) and Step 6 (COA approval).

What do the S3, S2 and Ex-O do in the war game? · The S3 plays the friendly maneuver commander, the S2 plays the enemy commander and other threat groups, and the Ex-O is the unbiased controller.

Which annex does the S6 prepare, and to what does the S6 give input? · Annex H (Signal); input goes to Annex C and Appendix 12 (Cyberspace Electromagnetic Activities).

Course source

Military Decision-Making Process · Student Handout